

Technical Insights: How to Manage Admin Privileges on Endpoints

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**Malware-free
activity accounted
for 79% of intrusions**



SECURITY BREACH

Source: [2025 Global Threat Report from CrowdStrike](#)

A man with dark hair and glasses, wearing a white button-down shirt, is seated at a desk. He is looking down at a laptop, with his hands on the keyboard. A white cup of coffee sits on the desk in front of him. The background is a softly lit office or home workspace with a bookshelf and some decorative items.

**Removing local admin
privileges and controlling
execution has mitigated
75% of Microsoft's
critical vulnerabilities.**

Source: [2023 Microsoft Vulnerabilities Report From BeyondTrust](#)

Agenda



Challenges and
limitations



Recommended
solution



Risks and
pitfalls

Agenda



Challenges and
limitations



Recommended
solution



Risks and
pitfalls

Challenge 1

Organizations face the critical challenge of balancing **user productivity with least privilege principles** on endpoints.

Challenge 2

Tailoring privileged access for diverse user groups such as administrators, developers, and business users across endpoints is **operationally complex.**

Limitations of UAC and LAPS



UAC is **cumbersome** and the user still needs **local admin account** to perform privileged tasks.



LAPS works only on Windows **domain-joined** computers. It doesn't **eliminate** local admin accounts.



The real challenge lies not just in addressing the risks of local admin privileges, but in doing so seamlessly — **without increasing admin workload and compromising user productivity.**

Agenda



Challenges and
limitations



Recommended
solution



Risks and
pitfalls

Recommended Approach

Remove local admin
privileges



Elevate specific
applications, not users

Recommended Tool

Core PAM Tools



PASM = privileged access and session management;
PEDM = privilege elevation and delegation management;
RPAM = remote privileged access management;
Source: Gartner

Recommended Tool

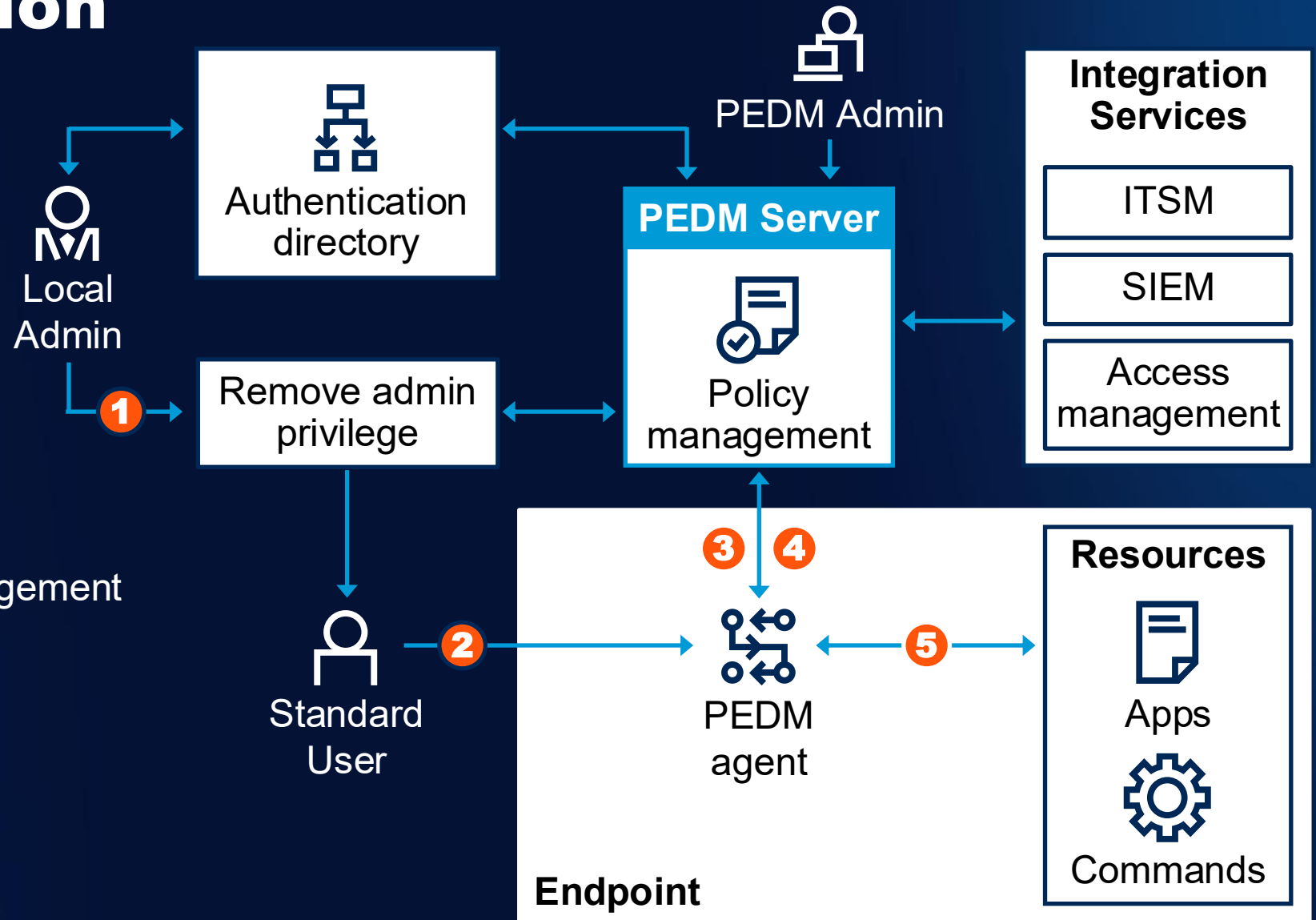


Privilege Elevation and
Delegation Management

PASM = privileged access and session management;
PEDM = privilege elevation and delegation management;
RPAM = remote privileged access management;
Source: Gartner

Privilege Elevation and Delegation Management

- 1 Identify and strip local admin privileges on endpoints.
- 2 Agent intercepts the request to install/ run applications and execute commands.
- 3 Agent queries the policy management service to check if the user is authorized to take the action.
- 4 Agent receives the decision after policy evaluation.
- 5 Agent enforces the policy decision on the endpoint.



Framework to Implement PEDM



Rollout gradually starting with a pilot

Run the policies in audit mode

Balance security and usability

Leverage trusted sources for automation

Build policies

Run the agent in learning mode

Install the PEDM agent on endpoint

Assess the need for deploying PEDM agent

Identify use cases and requirements

1 Identify Use Cases and Requirements

Discovery of local admin accounts

Privilege elevation

Application control

Command filtering



File integrity monitoring

Credential theft protection

Directory bridging

Malware protection



2 Assess the Need for Deploying PEDM Agent

1

User type	Requirements	Recommendation
Business users	Users who do not require local admin access	• Remove local admin privileges
IT users	Need to elevate privileges rarely	• Use LAPS (for windows endpoint) by default. • Consider PEDM agent on-demand.
Developers	Need to elevate privileges frequently	• Deploy the PEDM agent.

3 Install PEDM Agent

2

1

Lightweight component

Discover applications, processes and local accounts

Enforce policies on endpoints

Installation — Manual, software distribution system and push method

4 Run Agent in Learning Mode

3

Silent monitoring of activity

2

Comprehensive inventory of endpoints, applications and processes

1

Identify applications requiring elevated privileges

Understand user behavior and usage of applications and commands

Run the PEDM agent in learning mode for 2 to 3 weeks.

5 Build Policies

4

Discovery policies

3

Continuous monitoring and removal and local admins

2

Allow/Block/Elevate policies

1

Policies based on user type and role

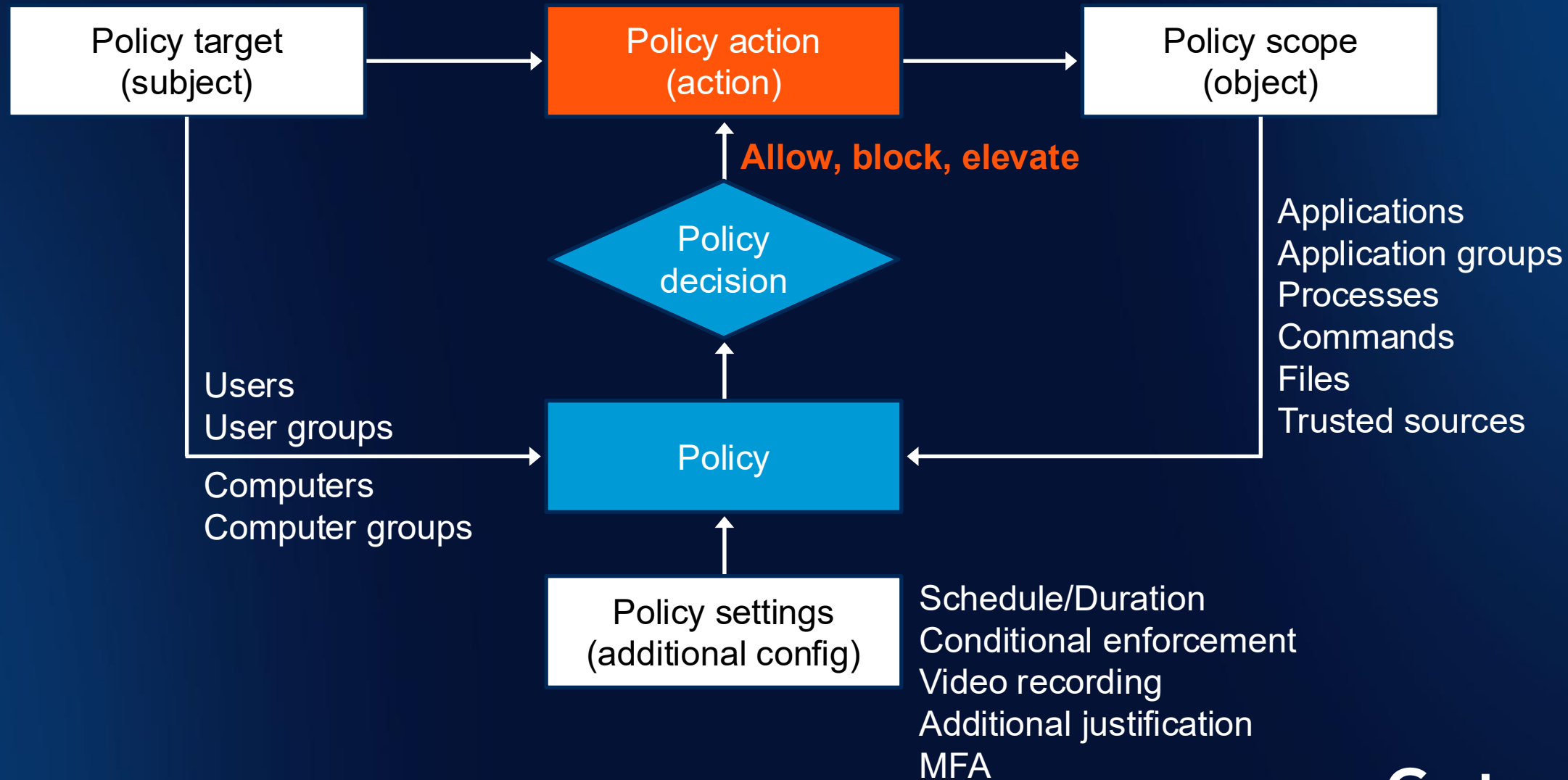
5 Build Policies (Policy Elements)

4

3

2

1



6 Leverage Trusted Sources for Automation

5

4



What is it?



How to use it?



Examples of
trusted sources

3

2

1

6 Leverage Trusted Sources for Automation

5

4

 What is it?

 How to use it?

 Examples of trusted sources

3

Trusted sources are mechanisms within PEDM solutions that allow administrators to identify and automatically handle applications or files originating from known, reliable origins.

2

1

6 Leverage Trusted Sources for Automation

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What is it?



How to use it?



Examples of
trusted sources

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Instead of creating individual “Allow” or “Elevate” policies for every single application, you create policies that apply based on the trusted source criteria.

6 Leverage Trusted Sources for Automation

5

4



What is it?



How to use it?

 **Examples of
trusted sources**

3

2

1

Digital signatures,
publishers, software
distribution systems,
trusted updater programs,
file shares, global
reputation lists

7 Balance Security and Usability

6

5



Default-deny



Default-deny
with grey-list



Explicit-deny
with grey-list

4

3

2

1

7 Balance Security and Usability

6

5

 **Default-deny**



**Default-deny
with grey-list**



**Explicit-deny
with grey-list**

4

- Explicit allow list

3

- Highly restrictive approach

2

- High dependency on PEDM admins

1

7 Balance Security and Usability

6

5



Default-deny



Default-deny
with grey-list



Explicit-deny
with grey-list

4

3

2

1

- Allow list + grey list
- Less restrictive approach
- Medium dependency on PEDM admins

7 Balance Security and Usability

6

5



Default-deny



Default-deny
with grey-list

 **Explicit-deny
with grey-list**

4

3

2

1

- Block list + grey list
- Least restrictive approach
- Low dependency on PEDM admins

7 Comparison of Policy Approaches

- Allow-list and elevate-list for known good applications
- Block-list for known bad applications
- Grey-list for unknown / unhandled applications

6

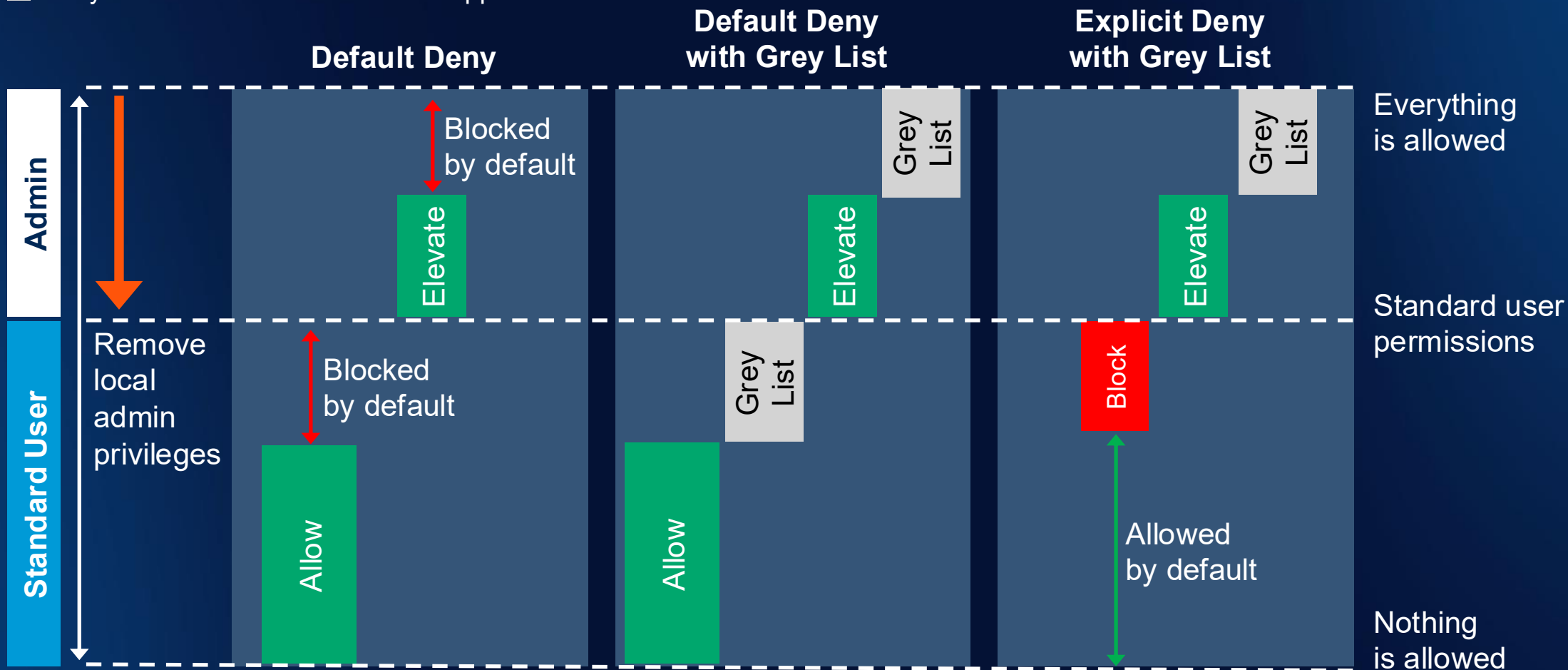
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7 Recommended Policy Approach

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Endpoint type	Frequency of changes	Recommendation
Workstations	High	Explicit deny with grey list
Critical servers	Medium	Default deny with grey list
Legacy systems/ fixed-function devices	Low	Default deny

8 Run Policies in Audit Mode

7

Provides a non-intrusive method to check policy effectiveness

6

Allows PEDM admins to test policies in simulation mode

5

Enables finetuning policies without chaos

4

Pre-requisite step before switching to active mode

3

2

1

9 Rollout Gradually Starting With Pilot

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1



Pilot group
(~20 people)



Few teams
in IT



All teams
in IT



Entire
organization



Finetune policies continuously **to increase automation** of privilege elevation requests.



Challenges and
limitations



Recommended
solution



Risks and
pitfalls

Pitfall 1

Increased administrative workload.

Solution

Automated elevation and appropriate policy approach.

Pitfall 2

Assuming that PEDM replaces all other endpoint security tools.

Solution

Use PEDM in along with other endpoint security tools.

Pitfall 3

Uninstalling or disabling the PEDM agent unintentionally or by malicious actors will hinder the endpoint's ability to enforce policies.

Solution

Exclusion reciprocity. To allow other security solutions to work side by side with PEDM, you must set mutual exclusions.



Noise-to-signal ratio of PEDM pitfalls is high.
Not addressing the pitfalls is as bad as not
implementing PEDM in the first place.

Recommended Gartner Research

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🔍 [How to Manage Admin Privileges on Endpoints](#)

Gautham Mudra

🔍 [Guidance for Privileged Access Management](#)

Homan Farahmand

🔍 [How to Implement Application Control on your Endpoints](#)

Eric Grenier

🔍 [Critical Capabilities for Privileged Access Management](#)

Paul Mezzera, Abhyuday Data, Michael Kelley,
Nayara Sangiorgio and Felix Gaehtgens